

Photograph by MANDAR DEODHAR

Q+A

"AGE HAS LIBERATED ME"

Actor **LARA DUTTA BHUPATHI** is enjoying her day in the OTT sun. The comedy *Kaun Banegi Shikharwati* on Zee5 is already the former Ms Universe's third web show in two years

Q. What is it about long-format storytelling that you enjoy so much?

OTT has completely changed the landscape for female actors. The content is far more exciting than anything we have done in the past. I love that there are women writers creating women characters who are so much more real and relatable. They are unapologetically imperfect.

Q. What was it like working with Naseeruddin Shah in *Kaun Banegi Shikharwati*?

Before Naseer saab came in, we were told he can be grumpy and has a short fuse. During the table read, he was just reading the dialogues. We had no idea what he would do in front of the camera. I thought it was quite cool. As an actor, you don't need to show all your cards immediately. You allow people to bring their A-game to the table as well. When we got on to set, he never made you feel like any less of an equal.

Q. You have said you don't want to limit yourself to lead roles. Why?

I wanted to be an actor, but because of my beauty pageant background, I was seen as a 'leading lady' and the films offered to me were in that vein. Age has liberated me from that stereotype. Now that I am in my 40s, people can finally think of me for parts that are beyond just glamorous.

Q. Is there a kind of role that no one's come to you with in these 18 years but one you would like to play?

I think I would make a fantastic diabolical villain, but I have never had the chance. I don't want her to be menacing, but someone who messes with your mind.

–with Karishma Upadhyay